

# Giraffes Can Do Simple Math, Scientists Find

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Giraffes are the tallest land animals on Earth, famous for reaching high into the trees. Researchers from the University of Barcelona in Spain have found that giraffes can do simple math.

The team worked with four giraffes at the Barcelona Zoo. In an earlier study from 2023, the same giraffes were asked again and again to choose between two **containers** holding different amounts of carrots and **zucchini**. Each time, they picked the **container** with more carrots.

Since the giraffes clearly liked carrots, **lead researcher** Iker Loidi and his team used them again. They placed boxes on a table at the giraffes' eye level. The giraffes saw how many carrots were in two yellow boxes. Then they watched as the scientists added carrots from a green box to one of the yellow boxes. To get it right, a giraffe had to remember how many carrots were in each yellow box and pick the one with the most.

Two of the giraffes, named Nuru and Njano, picked the right box every time. The other two used **shortcuts**. Sometimes they picked whichever box the scientist's hand touched last. Other times they chose the box that had the most carrots at the start. The researchers think giraffes, like people, may have different ways of solving problems.

All the giraffes struggled when scientists took carrots away or moved them between boxes more than once. This suggests they may find it harder to track amounts that change several times. Still, the results show giraffes can keep track of small numbers.

The findings were published in the **journal** Scientific Reports on June 26, 2026. The scientists think basic math skills might help wild giraffes choose the best food or keep track of others in their group.

## Word Treasure

**zucchini** -- A long green vegetable, a kind of summer squash.

**container** -- Something, such as a box or jar, used to hold things.

**lead researcher** -- The scientist in charge of a research project.

**shortcuts** -- Quicker ways of doing something that skip some steps.

**journal** -- A magazine where scientists publish their research.

## Background you need

Scientists who study animal intelligence design careful tests to see what animals can notice, remember and figure out.

Being able to judge amounts can help animals, for example by choosing a spot with more food.

Giraffes live on African grasslands and eat leaves from tall trees, so finding good food sources matters for them.

Tests at zoos let researchers study animals up close using treats the animals enjoy, such as carrots.

## Break it down

**LEAD:** University of Barcelona researchers found that giraffes can do simple math

**KEY EXPERIMENT:** Giraffes watched carrots added to one of two yellow boxes, then chose the box with more

+ - WHO: Four giraffes at the Barcelona Zoo; lead researcher Iker Loidi

+ - RESULTS: Nuru and Njano chose correctly every time; two others used shortcuts

**LIMITS:** All giraffes struggled when carrots were removed or moved more than once

**WHEN:** Published in Scientific Reports on June 26, 2026

**OPEN QUESTION:** How wild giraffes might use number skills, and how they process numbers

## Why it matters

The study suggests giraffes can keep track of small amounts, a skill that may help them choose food in the wild. It adds to research on how animals think and solve problems.

## Test what you remember

**1. Where did the giraffes in the study live?**

- ☐ (A) San Diego Zoo
- ☐ (B) A national park in Kenya
- ☐ (C) A farm in Spain
- ☐ (D) Barcelona Zoo

**2. How many giraffes were tested?**

- ☐ (A) Two
- ☐ (B) Six
- ☐ (C) Four
- ☐ (D) Ten

**3. Which giraffes picked the right box every time?**

- ☐ (A) Nuru and Njano
- ☐ (B) Njano and Iker
- ☐ (C) None of them
- ☐ (D) All four giraffes

**4. What was one shortcut some giraffes used?**

- ☐ (A) Smelling all the boxes
- ☐ (B) Knocking the boxes over
- ☐ (C) Waiting for another giraffe
- ☐ (D) Picking the box the scientist's hand touched last

**5. When did all the giraffes struggle?**

- ☐ (A) When the boxes were yellow
- ☐ (B) When zucchini was added
- ☐ (C) When carrots were taken away or moved more than once
- ☐ (D) At feeding time

**6. Which journal published the findings?**

- ☐ (A) Giraffe Weekly
- ☐ (B) The Astrophysical Journal
- ☐ (C) Zoo Science Today
- ☐ (D) Scientific Reports

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: C 6: D

## Questions to think about

**1. Researchers led by Iker Loidi: Think giraffes, like people, may solve problems in different ways and that basic math skills might help wild giraffes find food or track their group.**

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**